

CHAPTER TEN

The Comparison Trap

Kezia is in bed at eleven-fifteen on a Wednesday night in mid-November, scrolling.

This is not unusual. She does this every night. She does this even though she has told herself, every night for the last six months, that tonight she will not do this. She has watched documentaries about phone addiction. She has read the *put your phone down* posts on the very platform she is currently scrolling. She has set a screen time limit that she has, three months running, learned to bypass.

What is on her screen tonight, in rapid succession: a girl in Los Angeles who appears to have a clear-skin routine that involves seven products and a sunrise hike; a girl her own age who is at a basketball game in a city Kezia has never been to, in a sweatshirt Kezia knows costs two hundred dollars, captioned *blessed*; a friend from school who is, apparently, in Aruba this week — Kezia did not know this — captioned *paradise*; a girl Kezia has never met who is twelve, runs a baking account, has nine hundred thousand followers, and has just posted a slow-motion video of a chocolate ganache being poured over a perfect cake while soft jazz plays in the background.

By eleven thirty-seven, Kezia has felt eight specific things in succession, and none of them is good.

The eight things, in order, are something like:

1. *Mild interest.*
2. *A faint stab of why don't I have that.*
3. *The decision to ignore the faint stab.*
4. *The faint stab again, slightly louder.*
5. *The thought am I behind?*
6. *The thought am I doing this wrong?*
7. *A specific, bottoming-out feeling that does not have a word, but lives somewhere between exhausted and invisible.*
8. *The decision to keep scrolling.*

This is the Comparison Trap.

It is one of the great injustices of being a twelve-year-old in this particular decade. Comparison has always existed. Adolescents have always compared themselves to other adolescents. The new thing — the thing that is novel, in human history — is that the comparison set is now infinite. You are no longer comparing yourself to the thirty kids in your class. You are comparing yourself to every twelve-year-old on planet Earth who has chosen to perform a version of themselves, professionally and with good lighting, on a platform designed by adults to maximize the amount of time you spend looking at it.

You will lose that comparison. You will lose it every time. There is no possible curated self of yours that can compete with the curated selves of nine hundred thousand strangers. The math just does not work.

What you are comparing yourself to is not a person.

What you are comparing yourself to is a highlight reel.



Here is the trick the highlight reel pulls on you, and once you see it, you cannot unsee it.

The highlight reel is the top one percent of someone else's life, edited together with strategic cuts, presented with intent, often at angles that took fourteen tries to capture. The highlight reel is the moments their friends took good pictures of them, on the days they liked their face, in the outfits that worked, at the events that turned out fun.

What you are comparing it to is your behind-the-scenes. Your unflattering selfie that you did not post. Your boring Tuesday afternoon in your bedroom. Your kitchen at midnight with the dirty dishes you have not done. Your hair the way it actually looks at 7:42 a.m. on a school day. Your feelings — the messy, three-in-the-morning, *what is wrong with me* feelings — that you have never, ever posted anywhere.

You are comparing the worst of yourself to the curated best of strangers.

You will, again, lose this comparison every time.

This is not a flaw in you. This is not because you are uniquely behind. This is because the architecture of the comparison is rigged against you. You are playing a game in which the rules are: show your worst, see only their best, conclude that they are winning. No human nervous system can play that game without losing.

The trick is recognizing that the game is rigged. The trick is not playing.



Kezia, on Thursday morning, walked into Ms. Calloway's Tuesday lunch block — except it was Thursday, because Ms. Calloway also held a Thursday session for kids who wanted to drop in — and sat down.

Ms. Calloway said, *Kezia. What is going on.*

Kezia said, *Ms. Calloway. I was scrolling last night. I scrolled for two hours. I felt bad the whole time. I am still feeling bad this morning.*

Ms. Calloway said, *Kezia. Tell me what you saw.*

Kezia told her. The Los Angeles girl. The basketball game girl. Aruba. The twelve-year-old baker with the nine hundred thousand followers.

Ms. Calloway listened.

When Kezia was done, Ms. Calloway said:

Kezia. *I am going to ask you a question. You can refuse to answer it.*

Okay.

The four people you just described – do you know any of them.

Kezia said, *one. The Aruba girl. We have one class together. We have never had a real conversation.*

Ms. Calloway said, *so you know one of them slightly. The other three are strangers. The four of them combined are, in some sense, the jury you have been imagining in your head when you scroll. The jury has been delivering a verdict on your life for – how long.*

Kezia said, *years.*

Ms. Calloway said, *Kezia. The jury is not real. The four people are not actually rendering any verdict on you. Three of them do not know you exist. One of them is your classmate who, I would bet a small amount of money, has never thought about you specifically. The jury is something your brain is constructing out of their highlight reels. You are the one in the chair. You are also the one rendering the verdict. The jury is a hallucination.*

Kezia said, *Ms. Calloway, that is – that does not actually make me feel better.*

Ms. Calloway laughed.

She said, I know. The seeing-the-hallucination does not make the hallucination stop. It just gives you a small wedge for refusing to take its verdicts seriously.

She paused.

Kezia. Can I tell you something specific.

Yes.

Kezia. The cohort and I have been watching you carefully for a long time. You have a lot going on at home that you have not, in detail, told most of us about. I know about pieces. The cohort knows about pieces. You have been managing a lot, for a kid your age, mostly by yourself, while presenting on your Instagram a version of yourself that is fine. The cost of the gap is what you felt last night. The cost is real. The cost is paid in the eleven-fifteen scrolls and the bottoming-out feeling and the exhaustion.

The way out of the trap — and I want to be honest with you that it is not easy and it is not fast — is to make the gap smaller. Not by posting the hard stuff publicly. Not by performing the not-fine version of yourself for strangers. The gap is closed privately, in your real life, with real people, by letting more people see the actual you and not the curated you.

The cohort sees pieces of the actual you. Sofia sees more than most. Marcus sees some. I see some. Your grandmother — when she is having a good day — sees a lot. Each person who sees the actual you makes the gap smaller in your nervous system. The gap is not about Instagram. The gap is about how many real people, in real life, have seen the version of you that is not the highlight reel.

The Comparison Trap stops being so loud when the gap is small. Not because the trap goes away — the trap is the trap, the trap will be there your whole life — but because, when the gap is small, you have evidence in your real life that you are seen as

you are, by people who love you anyway, and the evidence makes the highlight reels of strangers less powerful.

Kezia said, Ms. Calloway. How do I — how do I make the gap smaller.

Ms. Calloway said, Kezia. Tell Sofia one true thing this week that you have not yet told her. Just one. Pick a small one. Tell it. See what happens.

Kezia said, *what if it is — what if it is big.*

Ms. Calloway said, Kezia. Start with small. You will get to the big ones. Start with one small true thing. The small ones build the road.

Kezia said, *okay.*

She walked out of Ms. Calloway's office. She walked to fifth period.

That night, instead of scrolling, she texted Sofia.

She texted: Sof. *Can I tell you a thing.*

Sofia texted back: Yes.

Kezia texted: *I was at the grocery store with my grandma on Saturday and she could not remember which aisle the bread was in. I helped her find it. I have not told anybody. I have been carrying it all week.*

Sofia, in Lincoln Park, in her bedroom, read the text.

Sofia texted back: Kez. *I am so sorry. That is a real thing to carry. I am glad you told me.*

Kezia texted: *thanks Sof.*

Sofia texted: Kez. *Anytime you want to tell me a thing, tell me. The cohort can hold it. I can hold it. We are right here.*

Kezia put the phone down. She lay in bed. She did not scroll. She slept by eleven-twenty.

This is what closing the gap looks like, on the smallest possible day. It looks like one text. To one person. About one true thing. The text does not solve anything. The grandma still

has dementia. The phone is still going to be heavy tomorrow.
The Comparison Trap is still going to be the Comparison Trap.

But Kezia, tonight, has slightly less highlight-reel and slightly more behind-the-scenes shared with somebody who matters.

The gap is slightly smaller.

The work is the closing of the gap. The work is slow. The work is one text at a time, one true sentence at a time, one cohort kid at a time.

That is the work.

You can do it.

You are old enough.